

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

SECTION A - Socio-Political Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

(a) "A classification of governments that counts rulers without asking whom they serve explains nothing." Comment. [10 marks]

Model answer (191 words; practice model, not official): Claim. The statement is correct, and Aristotle's grid is the demonstration of why. The argument. Aristotle classifies constitutions by two criteria: how many rule, and whether they govern for the common advantage or their private advantage. Crossing them yields monarchy against tyranny, aristocracy against oligarchy, and polity against democracy in its classical deviant sense. Why counting alone fails. Within any row the paired forms are structurally identical. Monarchy and tyranny are both government by one person; nothing about the number distinguishes the legitimate from the corrupt case. It follows that no purely institutional description - how offices are filled, how many vote, how laws are passed - can by itself deliver a normative verdict. A contemporary restatement. The modern dispute about whether an electoral regime is "really" democratic is Aristotle's purpose axis conducted without his vocabulary: elections settle the numerical question and leave the question of whose advantage untouched. Qualification. The purpose axis is not self-applying, since "common advantage" requires an independent theory of the good and every ruler claims to serve it. The axis is nevertheless checkable indirectly, through whether those affected can contest decisions and whether error can be corrected. Verdict.

(b) "A composite index of development is evidence, not a theory of the good society." Comment. [10 marks]

Model answer (200 words; practice model, not official): Position. The statement is correct, and its correctness follows from what an index is. What an index is. Every measure occupies an informational space and therefore fixes in advance what will count as evidence and what will be invisible. Output measures see market transactions; basic-needs measures see a deprivation threshold; welfare measures see reported conditions; human-development composites see longevity, knowledge and material command; capability measures see real opportunity; ecological measures see stocks, sinks and irreversibility. Why no index can be the theory. A composite must assign weights between dimensions, and the weights cannot be derived from within any of the dimensions. They are the normative question itself, which is why public reasoning about them is part of development rather than merely a technique for measuring it. Three concealments that decide arguments. Output measures cannot see unpaid work, so a society can appear to grow by monetising labour already performed. Welfare measures cannot see adaptive preference, so deprivation is certified as contentment. Composites cannot see within-group inequality. The qualification. This is not scepticism about measurement. Knowing a measure's blind spot is what makes it usable, and plural measurement with explicit spaces, under a stated deprivation floor, is the correct practice. Verdict.

(c) Distinguish legal from political sovereignty, and explain why the distinction matters for evaluating Austin. [10 marks]

Model answer (199 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The two answer different questions - who is competent to make law, and what power shapes or compels the law-maker - and the distinction matters because most objections to Austin are answers to the second offered against a thesis about the first. Legal sovereignty. It names the authority recognised by law as competent to make law: the juristic source of validity, and Austin's preferred angle. His sovereign is a determinate human superior, habitually obeyed by the bulk of society and habitually obeying no one. Political sovereignty. It names the actual power behind legal institutions - the force that can compel or shape the legal sovereign. Parties, public opinion, organised interests, military power, religion and economic classes belong here, and this is the standpoint from which Laski attacks. Why they diverge. A constitution may vest law-making power in one body while something else determines what that body can actually do; the divergence is a general feature of political life rather than a constitutional defect. Why it matters for Austin. An unlabelled objection commits a category error. Showing that a legislature is politically constrained does not refute a claim about legal competence; showing that power-conferring rules cannot be redescribed as commands does. Verdict.

(d) Critically examine the challenges faced by a multicultural society with reference to India. [10 marks]

Model answer (187 words; practice model, not official): Frame. The challenge facing a multicultural society is not that it is diverse. It is that equal citizenship and community-specific protection pull in different directions, and each of the standing challenges is a form of that tension. Four challenges. One - the internal-restriction problem. Recognition granted to a community may be used by authorised representatives against women, dissenters, lower-status members or converts; the criterion is Kymlicka's - external protections are defensible, internal restrictions are not. Two - essentialism. Recognition requires an interlocutor, and identifying one freezes an authorised version of an internally plural culture. Three - fragmentation. Differentiated rights are said to weaken common citizenship; fair recognition can instead deepen allegiance by removing assimilation as the price of membership. Four - majority invisibility. Only minorities appear "cultural" while majority norms pass as neutral, so scrutiny is applied asymmetrically. Indian illustration, labelled as illustration. Linguistic federalism illustrates accommodation; Articles 29-30 protect specified cultural and educational interests and are best read as external protections; personal-law pluralism illustrates accommodation while generating disputes over gender equality.

These show what a remedy looks like; they do not settle the internal-restriction question, which is a philosophical dispute. Verdict.

(e) Discuss the main factors responsible for caste discrimination. [10 marks]

Model answer (182 words; practice model, not official): Define precisely. Caste discrimination is graded, birth-based social closure sustained by a closed marriage circle - not "social stratification", and not a division of labour. The factors, as a chain. Endogamy closes the group and carries membership across generations. Hereditary status assigns social worth by birth, before any act or aptitude. Occupational closure allocates work by birth-group and stigmatises the labour itself. Purity and pollution rules moralise distance, so exclusion is experienced as duty, and religious sanction presents hierarchy as sacred. Social and economic power - land, employment and dependence - enforces the norm. Political mobilisation is ambivalent: it can democratise subordinated groups and can harden competitive identities. Why the chain form matters. Each link makes the next possible, so the system absorbs the reform of any single component: prohibiting the ritual practice leaves the marriage circle, and opening the occupation leaves the sanction. Inter-caste marriage reaches the first link; reservation the third. The consequence. The result is graded inequality - an ascending scale of reverence and a descending scale of contempt - which obstructs solidarity, because each level holds a stake in distinction from below. Verdict.

Q2

(a) "Monarchy, theocracy and democracy differ less in who rules than in how error is corrected." Discuss. [20 marks]

Model answer (392 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The statement is broadly correct and needs one qualification: the three forms differ in title as well as in error-correction, but it is the second axis, not the first, that decides the comparative verdict. Why the title axis is insufficient by itself. Monarchy claims heredity and tradition, sometimes divine sanction; theocracy claims revelation and sacred law read by authorised interpreters; democracy claims consent and political equality. Each title is internally coherent, and each has been sincerely believed, so the titles alone cannot adjudicate between them. The eight comparison axes. A comparison must run all three forms down the same axes - source of authority, type of legitimacy claimed, mode of succession, accountability, relation to law, treatment of dissent, equality of citizenship, and capacity to correct error. The last is the one candidates omit and the one that decides. Monarchy on the error axis. Error is corrected by prudent counsel and customary restraint. There is no regular, non-violent procedure for acting on the finding that a ruler is incompetent. The merit objection is therefore not that monarchs are individually worse but that no mechanism exists to respond when one is. Theocracy on the error axis. Correction is structurally hardest here, because the norm is held to be unamendable and its interpreter is insulated: objection to the interpreter can be recast as objection to the source, so dissent is reclassified rather than answered. Democracy on the error axis. Correction is institutionalised through opposition, elections, courts and public criticism, and this is the substance of the epistemic defence - not that citizens judge well, but that misjudgement can be exposed, contested and reversed. The objection. Democracies also fail to correct: form can be retained while substance erodes, so elections, courts, press and opposition may persist while fair contest, independent adjudication and realistic alternation are hollowed out. Reply: this concedes that democracy's advantage is conditional, not automatic; where the conditions survive, correction remains available, and where they do not, the regime has ceased to be constitutional in substance whatever its form. Weber's cross-check. Traditional and charismatic claims solve succession or inspiration but not answerability, while legal-rational authority makes correction a matter of rule rather than of the ruler's grace. Verdict. Classification by number tells us who decides; classification by legitimacy tells us why they are obeyed; the error-correction axis tells us which arrangement can survive being wrong.

(b) "Democracy is best defined by its method, not by its outcome." Critically examine with reference to Schumpeter. [15 marks]

Model answer (290 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The statement is defensible as a minimum condition and indefensible as a complete definition, and the distinction between those two claims is the whole argument. Schumpeter's position. Rejecting the classical doctrine that democracy realises the will of the people, Schumpeter defines it as the institutional arrangement in which individuals acquire the power to decide by means of a competitive struggle for the people's vote; the people's function is to produce a government, not to govern. The reasoning. The common good is not uniquely determinable; no determinate will of the people exists, since aggregate preferences are unstable and manufactured; and the ordinary citizen's grasp of remote issues is weak. Therefore democracy cannot be defined by the content of outcomes and can be defined by a method. What the definition secures. It is empirically usable, distinguishes democracy from plebiscitary acclamation, and isolates the minimum without which nothing else survives - an open, uncertain, repeatable contest. The objections. The participatory and deliberative reply is that the account is deflationary: citizenship becomes periodic choice among elites, the developmental value of participation disappears, and no criterion distinguishes a deliberative election from a well-managed one. A sharper objection follows: if preferences are manufactured, elite competition is a contest to manufacture them better rather than a mechanism of accountability. Replies and residue. Schumpeter's defender answers that this is a floor, not a ceiling: participation without competition can be mobilised acclamation. But answering the manufacturing objection requires plural media, independent adjudication and rights of opposition - conditions he does not himself supply, which concedes that a purely procedural definition is incomplete. Verdict. The method is necessary and not sufficient. Democracy is best identified by its method and best evaluated by whether the conditions of that method are genuinely present.

(c) Critically examine the claim that modernisation describes a neutral and inevitable process of social transformation. [15 marks]

Model answer (299 words; practice model, not official): Position. The claim is false as stated, though what modernisation describes is largely accurate; the falsity lies in the words "neutral" and "inevitable". What is accurate. Industrialisation, urbanisation, mass education, occupational differentiation, bureaucratic capacity, scientific rationality and expanding markets are real processes, and

denying them is not available to a serious answer. What converts description into theory. Five assumptions: a linear sequence of broadly comparable stages; convergence of institutional differences as capacity grows; a traditional/modern contrast in which inherited authority yields to rational, mobile institutions; diffusion of capital, knowledge and technology as a transmission mechanism; and expert direction, the warrant for planners to identify obstacles and accelerate the transition. The four hostile objections, each located. Dependency denies sequence and convergence: underdevelopment can be produced through unequal incorporation rather than inherited as an earlier stage. Post-development denies expert direction: it questions the authority by which external experts define whole societies as deficient. Cultural and Gandhian critique denies the traditional/modern contrast, refusing to concede that one conception of the good life is simply superior. Marxist criticism denies convergence and diffusion by asking who owns production and appropriates the gains. And the Ambedkarite question tests the whole package: does modernisation dismantle graded hierarchy, or merely reorganise it into new occupations and offices? The objection to the critique. If no comparable sequence exists, cross-societal comparison becomes impossible and the idea of development collapses. Reply: what is denied is a single universal route, not comparability. Capacities such as being nourished, schooled, safe from premature death and able to participate are comparable without presupposing one path. Verdict. Modernisation names real structural transformations but is not a neutral or inevitable law; its institutions count as progress only where they enlarge equal capability, democratic agency and ecological security - which is plural development under universal constraints.

Q3

(a) "Sustainable development is a policy formula, not a philosophy." Critically discuss with reference to moral standing, duties to future persons and the distribution of ecological burdens. [20 marks]

Model answer (391 words; practice model, not official): Position. The statement is correct about the formula and wrong as a conclusion: the formula rests on philosophical claims that can be stated, and stating them is what gives it content. Moral standing - the first prior question. Three orientations differ over what counts morally, not over how much nature to protect. Anthropocentrism counts human beings and protects nature instrumentally, permitting destruction where no human interest is engaged. Biocentrism counts every individual living thing but cannot adjudicate between organisms or protect a system as such. Ecocentrism counts wholes but risks subordinating individuals to systemic goods. The discriminating question - would it be wrong to destroy a wilderness no human will ever see, use or know of? - shows they are distinct positions. For a development answer the defensible position is a strong, non-instrumental anthropocentrism supplemented by duties of stewardship, stated and defended rather than gestured at. Depth of questioning. Naess (1973) distinguishes shallow ecology, which fights pollution and depletion in the interest of the health and affluence of the developed world, from deep ecology, which questions the framework generating those symptoms and affirms intrinsic value in non-human life. The difference is one of depth of questioning, not degree of concern. Duties to future persons. The Brundtland Report (1987) builds duties to the unborn into the concept itself (paraphrased). Three problems must be met: the non-identity problem, since different policies produce different people and the person born into a degraded world owes her existence to the degrading policy; reciprocity, since future people cannot vote or sanction; and discounting, since a pure time preference counts a person for less merely because she exists later, which is arbitrary in the way that discounting distance is arbitrary. The duty is best specified as preserving options and avoiding irreversibility. Distribution of burdens. Guha and Martinez-Alier (1997) show that environmental conflict in the global South is typically a struggle over livelihood, so "environment versus development" is a framing available only to those whose subsistence is not at stake. The degrowth argument must therefore be applied asymmetrically - contraction and convergence - and its weakest link, that a non-growing economy can sustain employment and services, conceded. Verdict. Sustainability acquires content only when thresholds, distribution, participation and non-substitutable limits are specified; and the ecological case strengthens the argument for participation, since durable transformation requires the consent and knowledge of those whose livelihoods it reorganises.

(b) Assess the significance of the pluralist lineage - Figgis, Cole and MacIver - for Laski's rejection of monistic sovereignty. [15 marks]

Model answer (270 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The lineage strengthens Laski's rejection empirically and supplies the concession his own account most needs, but it must locate the school rather than replace the printed thinker. Laski's position. The state is one association among many. Individuals belong to family, church, union, guild, cooperative, profession and locality, and these bodies command real loyalty; associations are not permissions granted by sovereignty. Figgis. Churches and other real associations expose the danger of an absolute state allied with economic concentration. His significance is as the group-personality and anti-absorption precursor: he shows that associations have purposes of their own that the state did not create. Cole. A forerunner of pluralism associated with functional or guild representation and socially organised group life. Significance: he converts plural loyalty into a proposal about representation. The boundary matters - analysis should not become a theory of guild socialism. MacIver. Law and constitution, not a mysterious sovereign will, ground legitimate public force; the state coordinates associations without creating all their purposes. Significance: this is both the strongest sociological supplement to Laski and the honest statement of what pluralism still owes to monism. Assessment. Figgis supplies the moral urgency, Cole the institutional imagination and MacIver the residual coordination role. The last is decisive: because someone must settle conflicts between associations, MacIver's coordination claim measures exactly how much of the monist case survives. Control and verdict. Laski is the printed thinker and the marks follow him; the three names locate the school. The lineage therefore makes the rejection of monism harder to dismiss as one writer's preference, while making explicit that pluralism limits sovereignty rather than abolishing the function it names.

(c) Can humanism be a substitute for religion? Explain and evaluate in the context of the present Indian society. [15 marks]

Model answer (275 words; practice model, not official): Frame first. "Substitute" is a functional relation: X substitutes for Y when it discharges Y's function. The question is therefore not whether humanism is truer or better than religion, but which of religion's several

functions it can carry. Four functions, four verdicts. Moral orientation - humanism supplies this substantially, since suffering, reciprocity, dignity and responsibility can ground conduct; the residual is disagreement over an ultimate foundation. Public ethic - supplied fully, since common humanity and reason can justify equal civic standing; the residual is that abstract reason must learn from cultural and historical experience. Community and solidarity - supplied partly, since associations, education and service create fellowship, but inherited ritual and belonging may not be fully replaceable. Meaning, transcendence and existential consolation - supplied only partly and for some persons; secular humanism does not reproduce every religious horizon. The Indian argument. In a deeply religious and plural society, a humanism that demanded irreligion would violate the equal conscience that secularism exists to protect. Gandhi and Vivekananda show that human concern and faith can reinforce each other; M. N. Roy shows that an ethical humanism can also be naturalistic. India therefore supplies both halves of the answer at once. Verdict. Humanism can substitute for religion's ethical and civic role, but not necessarily for its full communal, meaning-conferring or transcendent role. It is best defended as a universal floor compatible with, and critical of, plural religious consciences - not as their compulsory replacement. One concession completes the evaluation: for a believer who holds the four functions to be inseparable because a single belief grounds them all, the analysis does not apply, which is why the verdict says not necessarily rather than not.

Q4

(a) Critically examine the claim that the four printed thinkers on sovereignty are answering four different questions rather than giving four answers to one. [20 marks]

Model answer (387 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The claim is largely true and analytically productive, but it must be qualified: the four questions overlap at one point - every position must say what makes closure possible - and it is that overlap which makes comparison legitimate. The four questions. Bodin and Austin ask who is sovereign. Kelsen and Hart deny that this is the right question and ask what makes a norm valid. Laski denies that any single answer is possible and asks how allegiance is actually distributed. Kautilya asks what the holder of authority is for. Bodin and Austin - the "who" question. Bodin answers: the commonwealth's supreme law-giving authority, absolute and perpetual, limited by divine law, natural law and the fundamental laws of the realm. Austin answers: a determinate human superior, habitually obeyed by the bulk of society, whose authority is illimitable within the legal order. Kelsen and Hart - the validity question. Because "is" does not yield "ought", validity cannot rest on the fact of obedience; Kelsen derives it from a hierarchy of norms terminating in a presupposed basic norm (1945), and Hart from a rule of recognition existing as convergent official practice (1961). Laski - the allegiance question. The state is one association among many and must compete for allegiance by protecting rights, securing welfare and enabling meaningful life; monistic sovereignty misdescribes society and licenses domination. Kautilya - the purpose question. The ruler heads a seven-limbed state, governs through calibrated coercion, and is measured by security and welfare; authority is justified by what it delivers. Why the reframing is productive. Read as four answers to one question, the positions look like a disagreement of degree about how much authority is too much. Read as four questions, each exposes a blind spot in the others: Austin cannot see facilities, Kelsen and Hart cannot see danger, Laski cannot see emergency closure, and Kautilya cannot see consent. The qualification. The questions are not wholly independent. Every position must explain how a political community reaches closure, and each does: Bodin through an undivided title, Austin through a determinate superior, Kelsen through a presupposed apex, Hart through an accepted criterion, Laski through a final procedure, Kautilya through a duty-bound head. Comparison is therefore legitimate on that axis and illegitimate on axes the thinkers do not share. Verdict. The claim should be accepted with that amendment: four questions, one shared problem.

(b) Critically analyse the social and political significance of Ambedkar's notion of annihilation of caste. [15 marks]

Model answer (278 words; practice model, not official): What annihilation means. Not the removal of caste feeling by exhortation, and not the abolition of cultural difference. Caste is sustained by belief in the sacred authority of rules that rank and separate; isolated reforms leave that foundation intact; inter-dining does not open the marriage circle; inter-caste marriage attacks endogamy and creates social kinship; and annihilation requires rejection or radical reconstruction of scriptural authority, social rights and material relations. Social significance. It relocates the target from practices to the marriage circle and to the valuation of persons. Caste is ranked separation, not plurality: it fragments society into unequal, mutually closed groups, destroys fraternity, and denies free choice of occupation and association. Annihilation therefore aims at association and worth, not at etiquette. Political significance. Because caste narrows loyalty and obstructs public spirit, it disables the disposition to common action on which public life depends. A political democracy resting on graded social worth is unstable - one person one vote and one vote one value against unequal worth. Annihilation is thus a condition of social democracy, not a supplement to it. Objection. The argument proves too much: if the sanction is sacred, nothing short of dismantling a religious tradition can help. Reply: the fifth move names authority, rights and material relations together; rights and material relations are alterable politically, and the claim is about insufficiency, not impossibility. Residual limit. How the sanction is dislodged where conversion is not chosen remains underspecified, and state competence over belief is limited. Verdict. Its significance is that it reclassifies caste from a set of objectionable practices into a legitimated order of worth - which is why reform of the practice had repeatedly left the allocation intact.

(c) Can Theocracy be accepted as a valid form of Government? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer. [15 marks]

Model answer (289 words; practice model, not official): Name the test first. Validity here means acceptability as a general form of government, and the applicable tests are consent, equal citizenship, public reason and revisability. Without naming them, any verdict is assertion. The case in favour, stated charitably. Theocracy claims moral unity and collective purpose; it restrains purely self-interested politics by subjecting rulers to a law they cannot rewrite; and it offers a stable ethical order derived from sacred obligation. The second point is genuinely serious: purely procedural politics supplies no moral limit on what a majority may will. The case against. Citizens of different faiths or none receive no equal standing; liberty of conscience is compromised; dissent becomes

impiety rather than legitimate disagreement; clerical mediation produces an interpretive monopoly; and adaptation to a discourse of rights becomes difficult. The decisive structural point. The defect is generated by theocracy's own strongest claim. A law that no human may amend must still be applied, so the interpreter acquires political power insulated from criticism, since objection to him can be recast as objection to the source. Objection and reply. Objection: applying consent and equal-citizenship tests to a form that rejects them begs the question. Reply: the internal/general distinction avoids the circle - theocracy may be coherent and valid within a community of shared belief, and it is the plurality of the society, not the critic's premises, that defeats it as a general form. Verdict. Theocracy may claim internal validity for believers, but as a general form of government in a plural modern society it fails the tests of equal citizenship, public reason and accountability. Judged by moral limitation of the ruler, however, it identifies a real deficiency in purely procedural politics - one that constitutional rights can meet without confessional sovereignty.

SECTION B - Philosophy of Religion

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

(a) "Liberation is a family-resemblance term, not the name of a single state." Examine this claim with reference to at least four Indian schools. [10 marks]

Model answer (149 words; practice model, not official): The claim. One English word covers destinations that differ in what ends, what remains and whether consciousness is present. Four schools. Advaita: ignorance ends, Brahman alone remains, and awareness is self-luminous - liberation as identity. Visistadvaita: karmic bondage ends, the eternal individual soul remains in communion with God - liberation as communion, never absorption. Nyaya-Vaisesika: pain and the qualities sustaining experience end, the self-substance remains without consciousness - liberation as cessation. Samkhya-Yoga: non-discrimination ends, purusa stands alone, conscious but contentless - liberation as isolation. Add Jainism, where karmic matter ends and a perfected omniscient individual remains, and Buddhism, where craving ends and no self is asserted at all. Assessment. These are not degrees of one state; identity and communion are mutually exclusive, and cessation excludes the very awareness that identity requires. Conclusion. The shared vocabulary conceals incompatible destinations, and the first task in any liberation answer is to say which one is meant.

(b) "Analogy protects transcendence only by sacrificing intelligibility." Examine with reference to Aquinas and Scotus. (Answer within 150 words.) [10 marks]

Model answer (126 words; practice model, not official): The charge identifies analogy's risk but overstates its failure. Aquinas rejects anthropomorphic univocity and empty equivocity. Pure perfection exists in God essentially and eminently: the *res significata* applies truly, while creaturely *modus significandi* remains inadequate. Causal participation supplies ordered continuity. Scotus objects that inference requires a semantically univocal concept of being; otherwise analogy disguises equivocation. His certain-and-doubtful argument allows one to be certain that God is a being while doubtful whether finite or infinite. Intrinsic modes restore ontological difference. The Thomist reply is that causal dependence, not a common genus, grounds the middle term. Yet analogy must explain how its proportion is fixed. It preserves qualified intelligibility, not transparency. A defensible conclusion combines analogical predication, enough conceptual continuity for inference, and an apophatic limit on adequacy.

(c) Does the fact that religion motivates moral conduct show anything about the grounding of moral obligation? Examine. [10 marks]

Model answer (173 words; practice model, not official): It shows nothing about grounding, and the reason is structural rather than empirical. Religion's motivational contribution is real and identifiable: narrative exemplars, ritual formation, community sanction, hope and repentance, and a worldview in which sustained moral effort is intelligible. Behavioural evidence of religious influence on conduct is therefore unsurprising. But grounding, knowledge, motivation and sanction are four separable relations. Grounding asks what constitutes the validity of an obligation; motivation asks what supplies the operative reason to comply. A cause of compliance is not a constituent of obligation, and success in one column proves nothing in another. The point is sharpened by a canonical case: a vow of non-violence may be strengthened by religious discipline while its moral defensibility still requires reasons accessible beyond the community. The strengthening is genuine; the justification is elsewhere. Two further controls follow. Influence is contingent - the same mechanisms can sanction exclusion. And correlation may itself require controls for community, selection and orientation. Religion may therefore be motivationally indispensable to a particular agent and grounding-irrelevant at the same time.

(d) Explain how Buddhism can sustain a religious form of life without belief in a creator God. [10 marks]

Model answer (198 words; practice model, not official): Religion need not be defined by belief in a creator. Buddhism and Jainism organise doctrine, discipline, community and liberation without a sovereign God. Their objects of reverence are awakened teachers, perfected beings, truth and a path of transformation rather than a creator who commands obedience. Worship can therefore express gratitude, emulation and moral self-formation. Transcendence also need not mean a supernatural person: nirvana transcends craving and conditioned suffering, while Jain liberation releases the soul from karmic bondage. The objection is that ultimate law, the Buddha ideal or liberated beings may perform functions commonly assigned to God. Yet functional similarity is not identity. Neither dependent origination nor karma is an omniscient will, and liberation is not divine grace. Non-theistic traditions thus show that religion can centre on diagnosis, practice and transformation. They do not covertly restore God unless every object of ultimacy is defined as divine, a definition so broad that it erases the distinction under examination. The institutional test is equally important: monastic rules, confession, pilgrimage and ethical vows can sustain a religious form of life without prayer to a creator. The concept of religion should therefore be family-resemblance based, not tied to one Abrahamic model of belief.

(e) Discuss the paradox of omnipotence of God in the context of the existence of evil. [10 marks]

Model answer (172 words; practice model, not official): Mackie (Mind, 1955) frames the paradox as a dilemma: can an omnipotent being create things it cannot afterwards control? If it cannot, its second-order power - power to determine what powers exist - is limited. If it can and does, its first-order power over those things is limited. Unrestricted omnipotence in both senses is therefore incoherent. Three restrictions dissolve it. Omnipotence may extend only to the logically possible, which almost all theists concede. Or it may be second-order sovereignty freely self-bound in the act of creating free agents. Or it may be abandoned, as in process theism, where power is intrinsically distributed and divine power is persuasive by metaphysical necessity. The connection to evil is exact. The free-will defence requires one of these restrictions: God creates significantly free agents and cannot causally guarantee that they choose well. For Plantinga this restraint is chosen; for Griffin it is metaphysically necessary. Verdict: the paradox does not refute theism; it forces theism to specify which sense of omnipotence it is defending, and to pay for the choice.

Q6

(a) Can reason assess a claimed revelation without becoming its final authority? Critically examine the relation between faith, reason and revelation. [20 marks]

Model answer (293 words; practice model, not official): Faith, reason and revelation answer different questions. Revelation claims a disclosure unavailable to unaided inquiry; faith is the trusting commitment by which a person receives it; reason tests meaning, consistency and implications. A strict fideism associated with Tertullian or Kierkegaard protects the existential risk of faith, but it cannot distinguish revelation from fanaticism when rival claims conflict. At the opposite extreme, rationalism accepts only what can be independently proved and thereby reduces revelation to dispensable philosophy. Aquinas offers a mediating account: natural reason can establish some truths about God, while mysteries such as Trinity exceed but do not contradict reason. Indian traditions supply parallel models. Nyaya defends testimony through the competence and trustworthiness of the speaker; Mimamsa treats Vedic testimony as intrinsically authoritative; Buddhism asks claims to withstand inquiry and experiential testing. Reason therefore need not be the source of revelation to remain its critical tribunal. It can expose contradiction, coercion, failed prediction and morally destructive interpretation, while acknowledging that commitment also involves trust and practice. The balanced position is critical faith: revelation may enlarge the field of reasons, but no appeal to revelation should be insulated from coherence, evidence, ethical scrutiny and dialogue with rival claims. This position distinguishes assessment from authorship. A court can test whether a religious restriction violates equal dignity without deciding the truth of the creed; similarly, philosophy can examine a revelation's conceptual coherence without claiming to generate its sacred content. Historical transmission also matters: testimony reaches believers through language, institutions and interpretation, all of which are fallible. Critical reason is therefore unavoidable even in identifying what has allegedly been revealed. Faith remains distinctive because commitment outruns demonstration, but it should be proportioned to the quality of testimony and remain corrigible when interpretation produces contradiction or grave injustice.

(b) "Karma explains the distribution of suffering, but the explanation carries a moral cost." Discuss with reference to the theistic and non-theistic schools. [15 marks]

Model answer (269 words; practice model, not official): The explanatory claim. Karma answers a question theism finds hard: not why suffering exists, but why this person suffers. Act and its unseen potency (adrsta/apurva) mature as stored, fructifying and future karma within a beginningless series, so present condition is consequence rather than allocation. The two administrations. In Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa the law is self-regulating: no judge is required, and the moral order is a basic feature of how things work. In Nyaya and the theistic Vedantas God is the superintendent (karmadhyaksa) who ratifies and dispenses desert rather than authoring it. The fork matters: the first purchases economy at the price of a law without a legislator; the second retains a personal God at the price of subordinating him to a law he did not make. The moral cost. Because present suffering is read as the maturation of past action, the doctrine can be turned into an inference from suffering to fault. That inference is (i) epistemically unwarranted, since no one has access to the ledger, and (ii) practically corrosive, since it converts a metaphysical explanation into a social verdict. The replies. The traditions themselves block the inference: explanatory karma does not license social judgement, and the duty of compassion and relief is untouched by any account of desert. Beginninglessness also removes the "original fault" framing that most easily supports blame. Assessment. The explanatory gain is real and distinctive; the cost is not intrinsic to the doctrine but is easily produced by careless use. Conclusion. Karma should be presented as an account of why the world is orderly, never as an instrument for reading a sufferer's past.

(c) How far does Jain many-sidedness (anekantavada) resolve the problem of conflicting religious truth-claims? (Answer in about 250 words.) [15 marks]

Model answer (250 words; practice model, not official): It resolves a substantial part of the problem and leaves a residue that must be conceded. The apparatus is three-tiered. Many-sidedness (anekantavada) holds reality to be many-sided; standpoint theory (nayavada) makes explicit the standpoint from which a judgement is made; conditional predication (syadvada) prefixes assertions with syat, "in a certain respect", and the sevenfold scheme (saptabhangi) enumerates the modes. Framework-relativity is thereby marked inside the proposition rather than left implicit. This is not relativism. Relativism denies that there is a fact of the matter; conditional predication states the respect under which a predicate holds, so the assertions remain determinate and checkable. Predication is regulated, not abandoned. Its power appears at two points. In the absolute-truth debate it denies the premise that a finite formulation can exhaust the absolute, so belief in one absolute Truth no longer entails exclusivism. In the epistemology of disagreement it addresses Fogelin's problem directly: deep disagreement arises because parties do not share the framework against which evidence would count, and the Jain device makes that framework explicit - a genuine Indian contribution to a live Western problem, and worth far more than the parable of the elephant. Its limit is exact. The apparatus works wherever a difference of aspect, level or soteriological orientation can be specified. Where two claims contradict on the same question in the same respect - a personal creator exists, or does not - no index of standpoint helps. There, pluralism must distinguish literal conflict, symbolic

language and different soteriological aims, and acknowledge whatever contradiction survives.

Q7

(a) Compare the God-world-human relation in Spinoza, Samkara and Ramanuja, and assess which model best preserves both metaphysical ultimacy and religious life. [20 marks]

Model answer (326 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. Judged by metaphysical economy Spinoza wins, by non-anthropomorphic ultimacy Samkara wins, and by religious adequacy Ramanuja wins; so the assessment must name its criterion before it names a winner. The common axes. Three questions discipline the comparison: what is the world's ontological status, what is the human self, and what religious relation remains available? Spinoza. There is one infinite substance, God or Nature (*Deus sive Natura*), expressed through infinitely many attributes, of which we know Thought and Extension; finite minds and bodies are modes. God is the immanent, not the transitive, cause, and acts from the necessity of the divine nature, so freedom means self-determination rather than choice. Religious life becomes the intellectual love of God - understanding the necessary whole - while petition and grace disappear. Samkara. Brahman alone is real; the world is apparent transformation (*vivarta*), empirically available but sublatale; the self is not a part or mode but Brahman itself. The personal Lord is Brahman at the transactional level, so worship is valid but not final. Ultimacy is protected at the cost of making the worshipper's standpoint provisional. Ramanuja. Brahman is a qualified unity whose body is the real plurality of selves (*cit*) and matter (*acit*), related by inseparability (*aprthaksiddhi*); the world is real transformation (*parinama*), and God is both material and efficient cause. Selves remain eternally real, so devotion and surrender are ultimate rather than provisional. The objection is that defect in the body should infect the indwelling self; the reply distinguishes the controller's perfection from the condition of what is controlled. Assessment. If the criterion is parsimony, one substance with modes is unbeatable - but it abolishes address. If the criterion is freedom from anthropomorphism, non-dualism is strongest - but it sublates the devotee. If the criterion is the intelligibility of worship, qualified non-dualism is strongest - but it must keep answering the defect objection. Verdict. No model secures both goods without remainder; Ramanuja pays the smallest religious price, and Samkara the smallest anthropomorphic one.

(b) "Karma answers the question that secular ethics leaves open, but at a cost of its own." Critically discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (297 words; practice model, not official): The claim is largely right about the answer and right to insist on the cost. The open question is the undetected, costly, unreciprocated act - Glaucon's Ring of Gyges, Hobbes's Foole, Hume's sensible knave, whom Hume concedes he cannot fully answer. Every secular reply stops at the same place. Kant explains why the law binds, not why this agent will obey it. Gauthier's constrained maximisation needs dispositions to be detectable. Eudaimonism needs a thick nature the sceptic may decline. Reciprocity has an explicit exception clause for exactly the undetected case. Karma closes that gap in a way no theistic sanction does as cleanly. It is exhaustive - there is no unobserved act - and impersonal - there is no judge to petition or deceive. The Ring of Gyges presupposes that invisibility to persons matters; where the moral order is coextensive with the causal order, it does not. The Gita strengthens the position further: *niskama-karma* (2.47, 3.19) removes the fruit of action from deliberation, so the prudential question is not merely answered but dissolved. The costs are two. The first is unverifiability, which is the standing objection to this grounding as arbitrariness is to divine command and formalism to Kant. The second, if karma is presented as cosmic bookkeeping, is that it becomes prudence on a larger scale - Gyges with a bigger ring. The tradition's own answer to the second cost is *niskama-karma*, which is why the citation matters rather than decorates. A control must accompany any use of the doctrine: karma motivates the agent's own accountability and licenses no observer's inference of guilt from another's suffering. Karma therefore answers the motivational question with a reach no secular theory matches, and pays for it in verifiability rather than in moral worth - which is a better bargain than divine sanction makes.

(c) Discuss the relationship between man and God according to any one of the religions in India. [15 marks]

Model answer (242 words; practice model, not official): In Ramanuja's Visistadvaita, the relation between man and God is neither numerical identity nor external dualism. Reality is one Brahman qualified by *cit*, conscious selves, and *acit*, non-conscious matter. The individual *jiva* is therefore a real and eternal mode or qualifier of Brahman, and the world is God's real transformation (*parinama*) rather than an appearance. Ramanuja explains this through the *sarira-sariri* relation. As a body is controlled by, supported by and exists for its indwelling self, so every *jiva* is the "body" of God, who is the inner controller (*antaryamin*). The relation is *aprthaksiddhi*: the self is distinct from God but cannot exist or be conceived independently of God. Hence the *jiva* is not Brahman, although it is inseparably dependent upon Brahman. This ontology grounds religious life. The person remains a genuine knower, agent and bearer of karma; devotion is therefore not directed by an illusory self toward a provisional deity. Bondage contracts the self's manifested consciousness, while liberation expands it through knowledge, *bhakti*, self-surrender (*prapatti*) and divine grace. Liberation is loving communion and service, not the dissolution of individuality. The body analogy preserves unity and difference, but raises the objection that embodied evil may implicate God. Ramanuja distinguishes defects of the dependent body from the perfection of its controller, though divine responsibility remains a live pressure, and he adds that God consents to (*anumati*) rather than authors each finite act. The relationship is best described as distinct, dependent and inseparable communion.

Q8

(a) Discuss the main points of distinction between a priori and a posteriori arguments for the existence of God. Which one according to you should be preferred over the other? Give reasons and justifications for your answer. [20 marks]

Model answer (391 words; practice model, not official): The distinction is not merely one of subject matter but of evidential source, method, modal outcome and characteristic vulnerability. An a priori argument reasons from the concept of God alone, without empirical premises. The ontological argument is the sole classical instance: Anselm derives existence, and then necessary

existence, from the concept of that than which nothing greater can be conceived; Descartes derives it from the essence of a supremely perfect being. Its method is conceptual analysis, and its promised reward is enormous - if it works, it yields a necessary God, immune to empirical revision. An a posteriori argument reasons from some general feature of the world. Aquinas' Ways begin from motion, causation, contingency, degrees and purposive order; Paley begins from means-end adjustment; Kant's moral argument begins from the structure of moral obligation; and Nyaya's *Isvara-anumana* begins from the world as a composite effect requiring an omniscient intelligent maker. Their method is inference from effect to cause, or inference to the best explanation, and their conclusions are correspondingly probable rather than necessary. Their vulnerabilities differ accordingly. The a priori route faces Kant's charge that existence is not a real predicate, and Gaunilo's demonstration that the form proves too much; modal repairs shift the burden to an unestablished possibility premise. The a posteriori route faces Hume: the world-artefact analogy is weak, and from a finite effect one may infer only a finite cause. It is also exposed to scientific advance - Darwin against Paley, cosmological alternatives against the Kalam - whereas the a priori route is immune to empirical developments precisely because it is empirically empty. Preference. I prefer the a posteriori route, on three grounds. First, dialectical: it begins from premises the opponent already grants - that things change, that order exists, that we are obligated - whereas the a priori route asks the opponent to grant a contested concept. Second, epistemic: it does not require the illegitimate treatment of existence as a determining predicate. Third, traditional convergence: two independent civilisations, Thomist Europe and Nyaya India, arrived at structurally similar a posteriori arguments, which suggests the route tracks something real in the explanatory demand. But the preference must be graded. The price is that a posteriori arguments deliver at most a probable, possibly finite cause, and never the God of developed religion. If the criterion were modal strength rather than evidential contact, the ranking would reverse.

(b) Examine whether a quality-transcending absolute can perform the religious functions performed by a personal God. [15 marks]

Model answer (265 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. A quality-transcending absolute can perform the contemplative religious functions completely and the dialogical ones only by relocating them to a lower level; whether that relocation is a solution or a concession is the point at issue. The functions in question. A personal God supports petition, providence, grace, command, forgiveness and covenantal address, because knowing, willing and loving are predicated of it - analogically, not univocally. The Advaita reply. Samkara does not abolish these functions; he assigns them to the personal Lord (*Isvara*), Brahman understood through the cosmic power of appearance at the transactional level (*vyavaharika*), while quality-transcending Brahman is ultimate (*paramarthika*). Negation (*neti neti*, *Brhadaranyaka Upanisad* 2.3.6) removes limiting predicates, not reality; Brahman remains being, consciousness and bliss as its essential nature. What the absolute does better. It secures non-anthropomorphic ultimacy and unity, and it disarms the objection that finite psychology has been projected upward. Contemplative realisation - the recognition of an identity never actually lost - needs no responsive interlocutor at all. Objection and reply. Ramanuja objects that an entity with no determinations whatever is neither knowable, nameable nor worshippingable, so Brahman must be qualified (*savisesa*). The Advaitin replies that what is denied is limitation, not determinacy as such, and that devotion is genuinely valid at its own level. The residual difficulty is that the worshipper's standpoint is finally sublated, so devotion is preserved as provisional rather than ultimate. Verdict. On a contemplative criterion the absolute performs every function; on a relational criterion it performs them only at a level it also cancels. The honest conclusion states the criterion first and then the cost.

(c) What role do the concepts of evil and profane play to provide a firm foundation to religion? [15 marks]

Model answer (290 words; practice model, not official): The question is functional, not theological: it asks what work negative categories do in constituting religion. Durkheim, in *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), holds that all known religious beliefs presuppose a classification of all things into two opposed classes, profane and sacred, and defines religion as a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, uniting adherents into a single moral community, a church. The definition is deliberately God-free. A correction must be made at once: the profane is the ordinary, not the wicked; evil, impurity and the demonic are three further and distinct categories. Otto's *The Idea of the Holy* (1917) supplies the object-side - the numinous, *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* - while Eliade's *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957) shows the sacred erupting as hierophany, generating sacred space around an axis mundi and recoverable sacred time. The founding sequence follows. A religion first names a predicament - sin, impurity, suffering (*duhkha*), ignorance (*avidya*), karmic bondage. The predicament is marked by a boundary - pure and impure, sacred and profane - which generates ritual, prohibition and moral code. The boundary generates institutions: priesthood, initiation, purification, penance. The predicament generates a soteriology, the ordered path out. Indian material is the clearest case: the Buddhist First Noble Truth makes suffering the explicit foundation of an entire religion; Jain *asrava* and *bandha* name the predicament and *samvara* and *nirjara* the exit. India's founding defect is more often ignorance or bondage than moral evil, which yields diagnosis-and-insight rather than sin-and-forgiveness. Verdict: the binary is an ideal type, not a law, and wonder and gratitude are independent religious roots; but evil and the profane found religion structurally - they supply the predicament and the boundary without which soteriology would be idle. They found religion, not theism.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS